





Agra, I meet up with the extraordinary Alark Lall, a man keeping the zardozi art form alive in the most beautiful, personal fashion, right from his stately mansion, in the heart of the crowded main street. What looks like an innocuous colonial-era bungalow from the outside, houses one of India's most precious zardozi museums. Yes, you read that right, a private museum entirely dedicated to zardozi. Lall is the sixth generation of zardozi specialists and today he works with 12 master craftsmen to create high-quality zardozi, which is sold to affluent connoisseurs and customers across the globe. Zardozi, dates back to the Mughals and comes from Persia, and is a precious technique of weaving beards, sequins and metallic pieces, exquisitely onto fabrics to create magnificent, rich patterns in embroidery. "While zardozi continues to be extremely popular in mainstream fashion," Lall tells me, "there is a cultural awareness that must coexist with demand and appreciation. People might wear zardozi creations but not really know the story about royal patronage and how it was brought to this country from Persia, and remained for centuries." Lall's archives document pictures and letters from some of his royal patrons----Queen Elizabeth, King George V, Queen Mary and even Indira Gandhi and Jackie O. A frame of King George V's coronation, where the coronation robe featured zardozi embroidery, of course, finds pride of place in his stupendous collection.

State-sponsored patronage

Rajasthan has long played an important role in culture, art and heritage, often christened as the unofficial cultural and artistic nerve centre of the country. The erstwhile royal families of Rajasthan continue to work very closely with myriad artisans to revive and keep alive different art forms. More recently, the remarkable work

Clockwise from top left: Udaipur's Ganesh Emporium works with clusters of artisans and also revives pichwai The highly-prized meenakari work from Jaipur's master craftsmen

